cave-in by the Left, are still live issues—alleged corruption of TMC leaders, a fragile law and order, and the old accusation of minority appeasement. The TMC routine parry is to vociferously deny the charges, while play up the saffron party's "divisive politics". The possible implementation of the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) and non-payment of the state's dues under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA) have bolstered its hand. However, just like the BJP depends on its talismanic PM, the real ace up Trinamool's sleeve is the magnetic pull of Mamata. Even as investigating agencies uncover details of alleged corruption, Mamata's image remains largely untarnished. She consciously mines this. Her words to the crowd in Coochbehar, before the first phase, were revelatory: "think of my face" while voting. The TMC also draws confidence from beating back an ascendant BJP in the 2021 assembly polls. The main architect of that win, Mamata's nephew and political heir, TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, is spearheading the campaign this time too.

No one expects miracles from the colossi that once dominated Bengal politics as incumbent and opposition—the Left Front and the Congress. Decimated in 2021, they have a toehold of two LS seats (won by the Congress) in Bengal.

Bane of Corruption

The TMC government has battled a string of corruption allegations in the past two years—the alleged teachers' recruitment scam in which the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested state minister Partha Chatterjee in 2022 is the most prominent. That memory was revived on April 22 when the Calcutta High Court cancelled the appointment of 25,753 government school teachers under the 2016 recruitment process. With the BJP welcoming the move and the TMC appealing the verdict in the Supreme Court, the issue snowballed into a major poll plank. On April 29, the apex court declined to issue an interim order to stay the HC decision.

Then there was the cattle smuggling



CRY FOR WOMEN BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari (left) with state BJP chief Sukanta Majumdar at Sandeshkhali, Mar. 10

PTI

ACTION NOTES

TRINAMOOL CONGRESS

- Project BJP as anti-Bengal by highlighting cessation of central funds under NREGA, PMAY-G
- Hold on to women beneficiaries of state welfare schemes
- Clearing part of due wages under NREGA till Dec. 2021, promise to pay PMAY-G money
- Consolidating Muslim votes by suggesting that CAA will isolate the community

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

- Highlight corruption cases, link it directly to Mamata Banerjee
- Using CAA to woo Matua voters; focus on Rajbongshis and tribals
- Project Sandeshkhali as indicative of plight of women in Bengal
- Use issues like Hindutva, 'illegal immigrants', 'Muslim appeasement'

LEFT-CONGRESS COMBINE

- Project themselves as an alternative force beyond BJP-TMC binary
- Focus on corruption under TMC, communal politics of BJP
- Vouch on young faces who have credibility amongst people
- Raising Roti-Kapda-Makan as real issues instead of religion and caste